Transforming Diversity in Residence Life
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**Introduction**

In both residential life and the broader field of student affairs, it has become good practice to implement peer-to-peer education in a variety of functional areas, including leadership, diversity, and civic engagement (Mitchell, Gillon, Reason, & Ryder, 2016). Given recent events, such as the Charlottesville protests and the rise of white supremacy ideologies on campuses and communities across the country, it is more of an imperative than ever for student affairs educators to educate a diverse array of students on matters pertaining to power, privilege, and oppression, and call attention to how these systems are showing up on our campuses.

With this in mind, particularly with regards to the myriad of populations that are served by college and university residential life departments, it is imperative that residential life units foster an environment that is not only diverse, but inclusive as well. From this perspective, one echoed in the Indiana University Residential Programs and Services (RPS) Mission Statement ("About Us." n.d., para 1-4), we would like to highlight the CommUNITY Education Program (CUE, formerly known as Diversity Associates) as an exemplary practice housed within Residential Programs and Services at Indiana University.

The mission of the CommUNITY Education (CUE) Program is to foster respect and understanding in the residence hall communities and to create an environment that seeks, welcomes, and values all people. In pursuit of this mission, the CUE Program serves as a resource for the residence hall and IU communities and provides innovative and quality programs that create dynamic opportunities, generate dialogue, challenge assumptions, and support both personal and community development. Through such programs the aim is designed to engage and motivate individuals at all levels of understanding to become active learners who comprehend diversity and contribute to difficult dialogue across college campuses.

Managerial Structure

Figure 1.1 outlines the structure of the CommUNITY Education program.

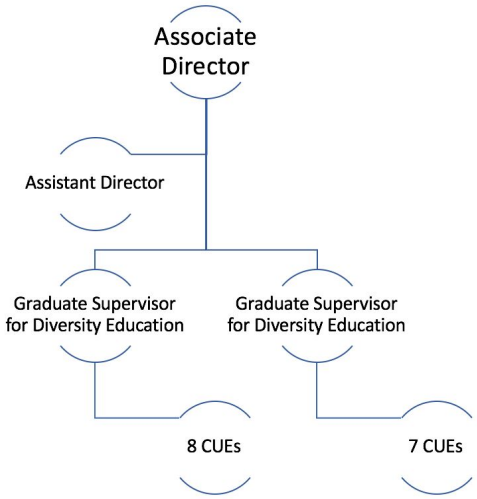


**Fig 1.1**

The CUE program began in 1989 and has continued to educate students, staff and even faculty through the CommUNITY Educators (CUEs) who are specialist in social justice and diversity programming. The CUE program has created a unique niche among residential student staff members, where each center's CUE is integrated into the large staff dynamic and valued as a member of the team.Each CUE is also available to consult with in-center staff on

social justice-oriented programs and bias incidents in the halls. The CUE program connects back to the literature by reinforcing the positive impact that peer-to-peer learning can have in creating inclusive residential environments (Graham, Hurtado, & Gonyea, n.d.).

**Why this program?**

The CUE program is exemplary for many different reasons. One reason for this is the basic fact that there are very few post-secondary institutions that have programs like this in the country, and even more specifically; within a residential life unit. Situating the program within the residential education unit is key in articulating the values and beliefs that the department wishes to espouse, ultimately shaping the culture of the department.The climate of the program and roles that support it speak to how it is prioritized within RPS and at IU. In addition, the CUE program is exemplary because it places diversity and inclusion at the forefront of Indiana University in several ways. It impacts students and staff in a meaningful way when it comes to supervision and support of the program. The different meaningful experiences include the MLK Civil Rights Immersion Trip. This trip has taken place for 15 years. This experience gathers fifty students, graduate students and IU staff members to explore the history of the Civil Rights Movement and sustain its legacy (Provost, 2016). Students really appreciate this experience and speak to it being meaningful and worthwhile. Furthermore, they speak to the enlightenment they have about the construction of society and navigate tough conversations to find ways to stop systems of oppression on campus.

Another aspect of the CUE program that is exemplary is the way in which the reporting structure is arranged. While each CUE reports directly to a Graduate Supervisor for Diversity Education, they also report to an in-center liaison who helps to bridge the gap between the in-center operations and the broader perspective of the CUE program (L. Graham, 2017). This contrasts with similar peer educator programs that implement a live-in peer model, but such programs do not integrate the peer educators into the resident assistant staff in the same manner. This reporting structure removes a degree of separation between the CUEs and resident assistant staff, allowing for more direct and timely communication. Most importantly, the CUE is directly supported by a designated liaison within each residence center, typically an in-center graduate assistant.

The coherence between the RA and CUE roles are made clear to any potential applicants from the time that they enter into the applicant pool. This is articulated in the CUE responsibilities of their role, which includes the expectation that CUES ground their work in the residential curriculum model, provide support to residence life staff and student groups, and a variety of other tasks, including marketing and program assessment (IU RPS Employment, n.d). The program is innovative in this regard by utilizing the hiring process as more than a way to to recruit talented students for the program. By utilizing clear expectations from the beginning about the ways in which the CUES work in tandem with in-center staff, a culture is crafted almost from the very beginning that centers a spirit of collaboration, support, and learning that is simply not present in programs that lack this degree of integration.

**Campus Climate and Culture**

The CUE program highlights very important topics and promotes awareness and thought around important concepts and issues related to social justice, diversity, and inclusion.

In general, student learning happens when students' engagement with new experiences and are reinforced by supportive campus environments composed of peers and higher education professionals, and when it is encouraged by institutional policies aimed at both the curricular and cocurricular levels (Pascarella and Terenzini 2005; Terenzini and Reason 2012). Students, staff, faculty and administration all have a role in how campus culture and climate are produced. As colleges and universities are becoming more diverse, students must be in an environment that is reflective of that. There is a call on higher education institutions to build campus environments that support individual students, while holding students accountable for their personal behaviors and for how those behaviors affect the larger community (Reason, n.d). The CUE program is unique in the sense that it is one of the oldest peer-to-peer social justice education programs for a residence life program in the country. Having a CUE in each residence center influences the campus culture. Institutionalized policies enforced by staff, faculty and administration influence the climate. Further, climate interacts with organizational policies and practices. In fact, for some authors (e.g., Petersen and Spencer 1990), organizational climate flows directly from, and is dictated by, the institutional policies and practices.That said, one must understand that "climate" is multifaceted, includes people's attitudes and behaviors, and is more malleable than culture. Even the best interventions fall short of the lofty goals of higher education and are usually not transferable between institutions (Reason, 2013).

**Peer to Peer Engagement**

Although there are few programs like the CUE program, other schools have synonymous positions that are internal and external to a residence life silo. There is a program at Indiana University-Purdue University Indianapolis (IUPUI) where the students are called Social Justice Scholars (SJS). The SJS is a program that focuses on student-led programming for the entire IUPUI campus and designed to provide passionate students with an opportunity to develop programs based on their interests. Students are selected by their commitment to social justice and interest in providing a welcoming place for all students at IUPUI (DDEI, 2017). In addition, there are other schools in the Big Ten that have similar positions (however, they are more related to diversity and multiculturalism) and across the country in housing like at Central Michigan University (Multicultural Advancement and Lloyd M. Cofer Scholars) a Living Learning Community for students to academic achievement, community service, enhancing diversity, multiculturalism and inclusion. (CMU, 2017). Also, Clemson University. Many schools have similar student positions somewhere at the institution too. The CUE program is not just focused on social justice. Diversity, inclusion, and intergroup dialogue play a role. However, there is a lot of overlap, and often-times people interchange the different terms. The CUE program also centers it’s structure from the Residential Curriculum. From this, students are able to identify and discuss societal trends and issues of social justice, illustrate ways they can interact with the global community, and explore ways to be culturally competent. Additional Learning Outcomes consist of: students being able to identify and analyze aspects of intersectionality.

Peer to peer engagement has resulted in demonstrably positive results, such as the successful integration of peer mentors in academic seminars (Willoughby, 2013). The structure of the CUE program allows students to educate other students informally. One advantage of learning from people who know

each other is the positionality and context of knowing both parties have been in similar positions (Boud, Cohen, Sampson and Jane, 2001). For example, the CUEs are students just like the people they seek to pour knowledge into. Therefore, the role of the CUE in each center serves much like Peer Assisted Learning (PAL) rather than a teacher. With regards to fostering the skills needed to engage in Peer Assisted Learning, the U450 Foundations of Residential Leadership course is exemplary, as it addresses a gap in the literature pertaining to the transition from new hire to competent student leader or employee. It should be noted that completion of U450 is a requirement of the IU/CUE selection process at Indiana University Bloomington. A key component of hiring new peer mentors is that the new mentors be engaged in an effective pedagogy that equips the mentors to engage in impactful peer dialogue (Micari, Gould, & Lainez, 2010). This aim is articulated in the course bulletin for U450, which "prepares undergraduate student with the foundational knowledge necessary to be engaged within the context of residential programs" (IU Spring 2018 Course Browser, 2017).

**Stakeholders**

Currently, the stakeholders for the CUE program are small, but efficient. The stakeholders consist of students, faculty, parents, RPS staff, Office of the Vice President for Diversity, Equity and Multicultural Affairs (DEMA). The Office of DEMA (2017) mentioned their position to the CUE program is mainly to monetarily support the Civil Rights Immersion Trip each year. In this support, the Assistant Director describes the outcomes of the Civil Rights Immersion Trip to be centered around the Residential Curriculum (L. Graham, 2017). From this, students are able to identify and discuss societal trends and issues of social justice, illustrate ways they can interact with the global community, and explore ways to be culturally competent. Additional Learning Outcomes consist of : students being able to identify and analyze aspects of intersectionality. In addition, there are some current administration who are said to be stakeholders as singular entities rather than a specific office/organizations.

**Program Assessment**

The previous Associate Director directed the CUE program for 20 years prior to the Assistant Director transitioning into the role. In discussion it was concluded that there are several student learning outcomes which are in the process of being developed in the CUE program. Some specific areas included the assessment of the passive and intentional programming in addition the peer-to-peer education the CUE program integrates as a contribution to its existance (L. Graham, 2017). Although a work in process, the CUE programs current assessment comes through anecdotal things such as; people sharing that things are meaningful to them whether it be an active or a passive program as well as when people may be offended with Bulletin Boards (L. Graham, 2017).

There is an area within the CUE program where active engagement can increase. The Assistant Director discusses not allowing himself and those that support the CUE Program to be forced into a "diversity people" box that simultaneously pigeon-holes and can place the program in the arena of afterthought (L. Graham, 2017). There needs to be more focus on intergroup dialogue. This intergroup dialogue takes form in intentional and passive programming. The intentional programming occurs in person and engages different people together and the goals is to create dissonance. In addition, passive programming occurs in the capacity of interactive bulletin boards. These are

necessary to change the environment and allow people to be more culturally sensitive and inclusive to people who are and are not alike. It is a matter of creating an environment where students are showing up to engage in dialogue that will make the difference. More visibility and collaborations will also enhance the program so that it is stronger and more well known. I will also say that it can create a more credible experience for people to interact with. In these times, support for work that may "ruffle feathers" is necessary and partnerships can help with that.

**Conclusion**

The growth of the CUE program throughout the course of its 27 year history speaks to the impact and benefit that the program brings to the residential communities at Indiana University. As the program continues to mature, the Associate Director and Assistant Director for Diversity and Inclusion are hopeful that the CUE program will continue to develop partnerships from both academic and student affairs. These partnerships matter because it puts action behind the university's words by prioritizing diversity and inclusion as a collective. It also allows for each professional who works in functional areas outside of housing to participate and engage as a stakeholder. This enables the CUE program and partners to continue to positively impact all members of the campus community to promote a better campus culture and climate. Our campus community does not exist within a vacuum. The Indiana University community recognizes a variety of ideals, values, and perspectives. As students in particular continue to wrestle with the prominent issues of our time, the importance of the CUE program in helping students to navigate these social issues will only continue to grow. To this end, we hope that Residential Programs and Services will continue to provide resources and support to this exemplary program as it seeks to achieve its stated mission to "create an environment that seeks, welcomes, and values all people" ("CommUNITY Education Program." n.d., para 2-3).

**Resources**


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